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to lead the fight from the front »

VIKRAM RATHOUR

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Vikram Rathour's journey as the Indian team's batting coach since 2019 has been remarkable. He witnessed the team's embarrassing 36 all out in the Adelaide

Test in 2020, but those bitter memories were wiped away when India won the 2024 T20 World Cup in Barbados.

Rathour looks back on his coaching career in this interview with *Sportstar*.

How do you look back at your tenure as a batting coach after serving Indian cricket as a national selector?

I've been incredibly fortunate that my journey has progressed within Indian cricket. I served as a selector for four years, starting in September 2012. Coaching has always been my first love, and I transitioned into that role before becoming a director at the Himachal Pradesh Cricket Association. Eventually, I had the opportunity to work with the Indian team. Throughout this incredible journey, I've experienced many ups and downs, gained invaluable

knowledge, formed lasting friendships, and built excellent bonds. Working with a great set of boys has been truly rewarding.

What was on your mind when the offer came to you? Was deciding between coaching, selection, and ultimately being in the dressing room challenging?

When I returned from England in 2010 (after retiring, Rathour lived in England for a few years), I got into coaching right away. I was coaching the Punjab team, then worked with the [Indian Premier League] franchise Punjab Kings for a few years. Then the selector's offer came, to which I said yes. Once I was done with the selector's job for four years, I was always going to go back to coaching; there was no doubt that I enjoyed working as a coach. It wasn't a difficult decision because that was always something that I was looking to do.

What did you learn as a selector and then as a coach? You had to make some tough decisions, especially with such a

star-studded Indian team.

That comes with the job. Selection isn't just about choosing players; it also involves the difficult task of dropping someone. During that period, the team was in transition, with many senior players gradually being replaced. Thankfully, it all turned out well. As a coach, you need to be fair with the big names. I always believed it's better to err on the side of giving one extra chance than one less. It would help if you provided one more game or extra opportunity. But there are still some decisions to be made. And sometimes, unfortunately, things don't work out with some cricketers. And there are times when you need to move ahead.

During your time as a selector, can you share some of the players who struck you as a longtime investment?

We picked Mohammed Shami, Jasprit Bumrah, KL Rahul and Shikhar Dhawan and even helped Rohit Sharma grow as a player in his initial phase. But to say that everybody we picked went on to become a good